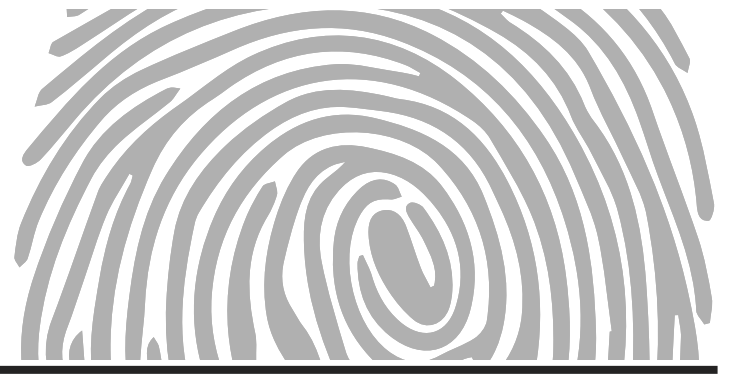


THE SLEUTH

BLACKMAN DETECTIVE SERVICES
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DECEMBER 2024



FROM THE CASE FILES: SANTA'S HO-HO-HORRIBLE SECRET

In a small town south of Pittsboro, North Carolina, one man played Santa for the entirety of the townsfolk every year. Children and parents adored him alike. But his beloved wife - Mrs. Claus, if you will - was having doubts about this Saint's ability to keep his presents in his sleigh. Not sure the reindeer would approve of these games...

"I'm ho-ho-horrified to say this, but I think Santa might on the naughty list this year! He's been disappearing a few nights a week for the past few months claiming to be practicing his Santa routine at the local rec center, but I'm not buying it." Mrs. Claus began to hyperventilate. I lit a peppermint scented candle on her kitchen counter to help her calm down a bit. She smiled weakly, as a piece of tinsel from her handmade snowflake ceiling decor fell to the floor.

"Really? What do you think Santa's actually up to, then? Have you tried following him when he leaves to see where he goes?"

"Oh, I can't bring myself to check up on him. It would hurt too much to see the truth with my own eyes. We've been married for a very long time, you know. But...my fear is that he's been paying an early visit to some of the ladies in the neighborhood for some extra cookies...or even worse...toys! Can you do a chimney sweep on all the local neighbors' houses? See if there are any finger prints?"

"Ma'am, unfortunately I cannot. The man wears gloves! It's part of his costume."

"His seasonal uniform, you mean!" Mrs. Claus exclaimed, shaking her head at me with disapproval.

"Yes, yes, my apologies - his seasonal uniform. Either way...no can do."

"Well...what CAN we do? He's obviously keeping a very ho-ho-horrible secret from me! I've done so much for this man over the years. I gave him 5 elves - oops, I mean children - and raised them while he was too busy working, taking care of the townsfolk!"

"I'll keep a watchful eye on Santa, conduct some surveillance. I'll follow him during the time he claims to be out practicing his Santa routine at the local rec center, which - ma'am, let's face the holiday music - he should already have down pat by now after doing this act for decades." I hated being such a scrooge, but I had to admit that the situation seemed grim.

Later that night, I was on-site. I zoomed in with my video camera... my, Santa had impressively muscular calves! This guy clearly never skipped leg day at the gym, that's for sure. But...wait...were those ballet shoes dangling from his duffle bag?

I tailgated someone walking in the side door to the studio. Immediately, it hit me. He was participating in this season's Nutcracker ballet and wanted to surprise her! Turns out, the man wasn't cheating at all! Spreading his legs, Santa managed to achieve the perfect split, wielding two tutu-clad sugar plum fairies above his head like Baby Jesus, Himself. Lord, have mercy! Saint Nick was a talented fellow, truly! Personally, I was always a big fan of the Nutcracker. Now knowing that Santa would be in it made it all the more magical for my own inner child. 'Tis the season for making dreams come true, it appeared!

I drove home, dialing up my client using Bluetooth. Visions of sugarplums danced in my head as I prepared to tell Mrs. Claus the sweet news.

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LITTLE RED FLAGS: IS YOUR PARTNER CHEATING ON YOU?



Nobody wants to feel like their partner might be cheating on them. Even if you're able to have the difficult conversation but the reassurance provide feels lackluster, here are 3 signs that your partner might, in fact, actually be cheating:

- **They accuse *you* of cheating.** Deflection to take the focus off of themselves leaves you too busy defending your own actions to question them about theirs.
- **They suddenly seem apathetic towards your relationship.** This may look like having no interest in spending time together, showing no signs of jealousy if you make remarks of interest about other possible suitors, and not seeming to put much effort into holidays, dates, or special occasions.
- **There are questionable changes related to their money habits.** This money might be mysteriously allocated to an unknown source instead of going towards previously-planned big expenses like home renovations or vacations.

Remember, these signs may be caused by another issue, so it is best to reach out to the professionals (hey, that's us!) to find out the truth. We'll help you finally get the closure that you deserve.

[Source: VeryWellMind.com]

JUST THE (FUN) FACTS: LIFE AS A PI HOLIDAY GIFT GUIDE EDITION!



Not sure what holiday gift to give to the PI in your life? We've got you covered! Here is our holiday gift guide, PI-approved:

- Upgraded video camera - enough said!
- Melatonin gummies for our whacky sleep schedules.
- Coffee...LOTS of coffee...for those early morning surveillance sessions. Either a bag of grounds or a gift card to a local cafe (gotta support local business, always!) will warm our hearts in this chilly weather.
- The boxed set of Magnum PI DVDs so we can live vicariously as if we're driving around warm Hawaii instead of shivering in our heatless vehicles.

Please...no more magnifying glasses!



CYBERSECURITY CORNER

SANS HOLIDAY HACK CHALLENGE 2024

As our queen - the one and only Mariah Carey - once famously sang: *"It's tiiiiiiiiime!"*

SANS Holiday Hack Challenge 2024 is now open! This free (talk about a wonderful gift, am I right!?) hands-on cybersecurity program allows you to practice your skills in a holiday-themed hackathon! Essentially, this challenge is gamifying practicing skills in mobile app penetration testing, cyber threat hunting, ransomware reverse engineering, OSINT via drone path analysis, and so much more! Consider us intrigued! The best part? A free holiday playlist to listen to while you complete all the challenges!

Sign up and learn more about how to fight against the bad guys on the Internet here: <https://www.sans.org/mlp/holiday-hack-challenge-2024/>

NOT TODAY, SCAMMERS!

HOLIDAY-RELATED SCAMS

'Tis the season for feeling holly jolly while stuffing your belly full of peppermint mocha-flavored treats, cuddling up with loved ones and furbabies by the fireplace, and being preyed upon by scammers trying to maliciously take advantage of the holiday cheer! Wait, *what!?* Whether promising you puppies that don't actually exist (there goes that perfect plan to get a Shih Tzu for your beloved Aunt Mary, darn!), impersonating your bank (with whom you've already got a love-hate relationship with during this time of the year), or Facebook Marketplace scams where you've found the most perfect emerald green velvet couch for your living room that screams "bougie on a budget" but is unfortunately as non-existent as the puppies are, you'll need to keep your guard up against potential scrooges trying to ruin the holiday cheer. Being aware of these types of scams is essential to stay vigilant when doing your shopping. Remember, if your gut intuition tells you something's off - you're probably right!

Source: [The Spokane Review, www.Spokesman.com]



CLIENT TESTIMONIAL

"If you need a PI that you can trust, reach out to Jamie and her team. They are very reliable, and it is always a pleasure to work with them!"



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